

Zostrianos

Codex Reference: VIII,1

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Editor's Introduction

Introduced and translated by John N. Sieber

The tractate *Zostrianos*, a heavenly journey apocalypse, is the major work in Codex VIII and one of the longest works in the Nag Hammadi library. Unfortunately Codex VIII suffered extensive damage prior to its discovery and conservation in modern times so that almost every page of *Zostrianos* is incomplete and some pages now exist only as fragments. Consequently, much of the text of the tractate is now lost. In spite of these problems *Zostrianos* offers an interesting example of how some Gnostics combined a mythological world view and a philosophical interpretation of it, based on Platonic thought.

The book opens with an account of the call of its central character, Zostrianos, to leave this world and to journey through the heavens in pursuit of saving gnosis. In antiquity this Zostrianos was linked to the lineage of the famous Persian magus Zoroaster. His call is recounted in autobiographical fashion. He was deeply depressed, ready to commit suicide in the desert, when suddenly an angel appeared to him and called him to gnosis. Leaving his physical body behind on earth, he ascended with the angel through the lower reaches of the heavenly realms. At each level he was initiated through a baptism into the gnosis revealed there.

As Zostrianos' journey continued he met a succession of angelic guides, questioned them and learned from each of them the gnosis of the various heavenly aeons through which he passed. The knowledge consisted largely in learning the names of the inhabitants of the heavenly world and sorting out the relationships between them. When his tour of the heavens was complete, Zostrianos descended once again to the physical world, where he wrote down the gnosis for the benefit of the elect, the holy seed of Seth. The tractate concludes with a brief but compelling homily in which Zostrianos exhorts his readers to abandon this oppressive world and to seek salvation through gnosis.

Zostrianos' mythological gnosis posits a high god named the thrice powerful Invisible Spirit from whom everything else has emanated. The physical earth and its inhabitants represent the lowest and most ignorant level. Between it and the Spirit lies a vast aeon system called Barbelo and understood as the "thought" of the Spirit. Barbelo herself is divided into three constituent aeons: the uppermost aeon is named Kalyptos (the hidden or veiled aeon), in the middle is located the Protophanes (the first-visible or first-appearing aeon), and at the bottom is the Autogenes (the self-generated or self-begotten aeon). Each of these aeons has its own system of constituent beings called lights, glories, angels, waters, etc.

The philosophical interests of the tractate are clear from its use of questions, categories, and terms best known to us from the Neoplatonic school of Plotinus. Zostrianos never tires of asking his angelic revealers about how this changeable world came into existence from an unchanging

source, or about why there are different kinds of souls or animals or human beings. Their answers assert that each successive layer of the universe is formed on the basis of the models in the layer above and that each layer is less perfect than its model. Of special interest is the identification of the three Barbelo aeons with the philosophical triad of existence, mind, and life. These and other references make it almost certain that this tractate is the one mentioned by Porphyry (*Vit. Plot.*, 16) as one of the spurious apocalypses in circulation in Plotinus' day and assigned by him to his pupil Amelius for refutation.

Zostrianos shares both its philosophical concern and some of its mythological world with three other tractates from the Nag Hammadi library: *The Three Steles of Seth* (VII,5), *Marsenes* (X,7) and *Allogenes* (XI,3). There are also some mythological ties, especially with regard to the names of the Autogenes system, with some of the more Christian works such as *The Gospel of the Egyptians* (III,2 and IV,2) and *The Apocryphon of John* (II,1 et al.), and with *The Untitled Text of the Bruce Codex*.

Except for a few allusions to the New Testament and Christianity in the extant text, the author of *Zostrianos* seems to have no specific interest in things Christian. He rejects the ways of the others, his opponents, but it is not clear if they are Christians or Platonists or some other group. His use of liturgical formulas, baptisms, and magical vowel strings indicates the book may have been used by a group of Gnostics in worship or contemplative exercises, but we are unable to identify this group on the basis of the reports of Christian heresiologists.